

## ACADEMIC POSITION

---

### Northwestern University

Evanston, IL

Assistant Professor (Tenure-track), Department of Communication Studies, School of Communication Sept 2023 –

Director, [Computational Media and Politics Lab](#)

Co-Director, [Computational Multi-Modal Communication Lab](#)

Core faculty, [Media, Technology, and Society \(MTS\)](#)

Core faculty, [Technology and Social Behavior \(TSB\)](#)

Core faculty, [Northwestern Institute on Complex Systems \(NICO\)](#)

Faculty Affiliate, [Center for Communication & Public Policy \(CCPP\)](#)

Faculty Affiliate, [Center for Human-Computer Interaction + Design \(HCI+D\)](#)

Faculty Affiliate, [Cognitive Science Program](#)

## EDUCATION

---

### Stanford University

Stanford, CA

Ph.D. in Communication

2017–2023

Ph.D. Minor in Political Science

Committee: Jennifer Pan (Chair), Jeff Hancock, Angèle Christin, Yiqing Xu

### Stanford University

Stanford, CA

M.A. in East Asian Studies

2015–2017

### Tsinghua University

Beijing, China

B.A. in Journalism (graduated with honors)

2011–2015

## PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

---

Note: \* indicates student or postdoc coauthors at the time of the first draft; = denotes co-first authorship

- [23] Muise, D., Cornelius, J., Lee, J., **Lu, Y.**, & Shapiro, J. (Conditionally accepted). An Open-Source Smartphone Screen-Recording Tool with Application to Political Science Research. *Political Science Research and Methods*
- [22] DeButts, M.\* & **Lu, Y.**= (Accepted). Intimacy with Limits: How Short-form Video Propaganda Embraces Platform Norms, but Not for Leaders. *Journal of Communication*.
- [21] Chen, K., **Lu, Y.**=, & Zou, S. (Accepted). TikToking Vaccine Nationalism: A Multimodal Understanding of COVID-19 Vaccine Videos on Douyin. *Mass Communication & Society*.
- [20] **Lu, Y.**, Liu, X.\*, & Zhou, C.\* (2026). [Recommending the State: How Social Media Algorithms Curate State-Created Content in China](#). *Journal of Communication*. jqag010
- [19] Divon, T.\*, & **Lu, Y.** (2026). [\(In\)Visible politics: Influencers as brokers of the state on TikTok and Douyin](#). *Convergence*.
- [18] Liu, X.\*, **Lu, Y.**, Peng, Q.\*, Qian, S.\*, Peng, Y., & Shen, C. (2026). [Seeing the Surreal: Mapping Surrealism in Photorealistic AI-Generated Images Using Large Language Models](#). *Computational Communication Research*, 8(2), 1-33.
- [17] **Lu, Y.** (2026). [Performative Propaganda Engagement: How Celebrity Fans Engage with State Propaganda on Weibo](#). *Political Communication*, 43(1), 99-127.

- [16] **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup>, Pan, J., Xu, X., & Xu, Y. (2026). Decentralized Propaganda in the Era of Digital Media: The Massive Presence of the Chinese State on Douyin. *American Journal of Political Science*. 70, 990-1006.
- [15] Dahlke, R.\*<sup>\*</sup>, Tu, F.\*<sup>\*</sup>, Wang, Y. C.\*<sup>\*</sup>, **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup>, Engeda, B. W.\*<sup>\*</sup>, & Hancock, J. (2025). Contextualizing Misinformation: A User-Centric Approach to Linguistic and Topical Patterns in News Consumption. *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction (CSCW)*, 9(7), 1-40.
- [14] Hanley, H.\*<sup>\*</sup>, **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup>, & Pan, J. (2025). Across the Firewall: Foreign Media's Role in Shaping Chinese Social Media Narratives on the Russo-Ukrainian War. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 122(1), e2420607122.
- [13] **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup>, & Peng, Y. (2024). The Mobilizing Power of Visual Media Across Stages of Social-Mediated Protests. *Political Communication*, 41(4), 531-558.
- [12] Qian, S.\*<sup>\*</sup>, **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup>, Peng, Y., Shen, C., & Xu, H.\*<sup>\*</sup> (2024). Convergence or divergence? A cross-platform analysis of climate change visual categories, features, and user engagement on Twitter and Instagram. *Public Relations Review*, 50(2), 102454.
- [11] Chen, K., **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup>, & Wang, Y.\*<sup>\*</sup> (2024). Unraveling China's digital traces: evaluating communication scholarship through a sociotechnical lens. *Chinese Journal of Communication*, 17(2), 127-150.
- [10] Christin, A., & **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup> (2024). The Influencer Pay Gap: Platform Labor Meets Racial Capitalism. *New Media & Society*, 26(12), 7212-7235.
- [9] **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup>, Schaefer, J.\*<sup>\*</sup>, Park, K., Joo, J., & Pan, J. (2024). How Information Flows from the World to China. *The International Journal of Press/Politics*, 29(2), 305-327.
- [8] Chen, A.\*<sup>\*</sup>, **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup>, Chen, K., & Ng, A.\*<sup>\*</sup> (2024). Pandemic Nationalism: Use of Government Social Media for Political Information and Belief in COVID-19 Conspiracy Theories in China. *The International Journal of Press/Politics*, 29(3), 710-732.
- [7] Peng, Y., **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup>, & Shen, C. (2023). An Agenda for Studying Credibility Perceptions of Visual Misinformation. *Political Communication*, 40(2), 225-237.
- [6] **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup>, & Shen, C. (2023). Unpacking Multimodal Fact-checking: Features and Engagement of Fact-checking Videos on Chinese TikTok (Douyin). *Social Media + Society*, 9(1).
- [5] **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup>, & Pan, J. (2022). The Pervasive Presence of Chinese Government Content on Douyin Trending Videos. *Computational Communication Research*, 4(1), 68-97.
- [4] Muise, D.\*<sup>\*</sup>, **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup>, Pan, J., & Reeves, B. (2022). Selectively localized: Temporal and visual structure of smartphone screen activity across media environments. *Mobile Media & Communication*, 10(3), 487-509.
- [3] **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup>, Pan, J., & Xu, Y. (2021). Public Sentiment on Chinese Social Media during the Emergence of COVID-19. *Journal of Quantitative Description: Digital Media*, 1, 1-47.
- [2] **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup>, & Pan, J. (2021). Capturing Clicks: How the Chinese Government Uses Clickbait to Compete for Visibility. *Political Communication*, 38(1-2), 23-54.
- [1] Reeves, B., Ram, N., Robinson, T. N., Cummings, J. J., Giles, C. L., Pan, J., [...] **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup>, et al. (2021). Screenomics: A Framework to Capture and Analyze Personal Life Experiences and the Ways that Technology Shapes Them. *Human-Computer Interaction*, 36(2), 150-201.

## BOOK CHAPTER

---

- [5] **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup>, & DeButts, M.\*<sup>\*</sup> (2026). How to Use Computational Methods and Online Experiments to Study Chinese Digital Media. In Xu, J., Guo, S., and Zhang, W. (Eds.), *The Sage Handbook on Chinese Digital Media and Communication*.
- [4] Chen, K., & **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup> (2026). Video as data in computational analysis. In Shen, L. (Ed.), *The Handbook of Quantitative Research Methods in Communication Science*.
- [3] Chen, K., **Lu, Y.**<sup>=</sup>, & Gaw, F. (Forthcoming). Evaluating Computational Methods in Communication Research: A Comparative Framework for the LLM Era. In Domahidi, E., & Haim, M. (Eds.), *ICA Handbook of Computational Communication Research*.

- [2] Kim, S., **Lu, Y.**, & Peng, Y. (2025). [Unmasking Deception: How Computer Vision Could Empower Visual Journalism in Unveiling Visual Misinformation](#). In Thompson, T. J., and Dahmen, N. S. (Eds.), *The Routledge Companion to Visual Journalism*. 39: 471-482. Routledge.
- [1] Peng, Y., & **Lu, Y.** (2023). [Computational Visual Analysis in Political Communication](#). In D. Lilleker & A. Veneti (eds.), *Research Handbook on Visual Politics*, 4: 42-54. Edward Elgar Publishing.

## CONFERENCE LATE-BREAKING WORK & PANELS (NON-ARCHIVAL)

---

- [2] Hwang, A. H.-C., Bernstein, M. S., Sundar, S. S., Zhang, R., Horta Ribeiro, M., **Lu, Y.**, Chang, S., Wu, S. Yang, A., Williams, D., Park, J. S., Ognyanova, K., Xiao, Z., Shamma, D. A. (2025). Human Subjects Research in the Age of Generative AI: Opportunities and Challenges of Applying LLM-Simulated Data to HCI Studies. Panel for *CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI 2025)*
- [1] Peng, Q.\*, **Lu, Y.**, & Peng, Y., Qian, S.\*, Liu X.\*, & Shen, C. (2025). Crafting Synthetic Realities: Examining Visual Realism and Misinformation Potential of Photorealistic AI-Generated Images. In *Proceedings of the Extended Abstracts of the CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems* (pp. 1-12).

## UNDER REVIEW

---

- [4] Gaw, F.\*, **Lu, Y.**, & Nisbet, E. Visual Logic: An Integrated Framework for Understanding Visual Content on Social Media (Revise and Resubmit)
- [3] Liu, X.\*, Peng, Y., & **Lu, Y.** Mitigating Confounding Bias in Observational Research of Visual Media Effects: An LLM-Informed, Machine Learning-Based Inference Framework (Revise and Resubmit)
- [2] **Lu, Y.**, Xin, H.\*, Chu, A.\*, Peng, Y., & Shen, C. Measuring Sound Events in Political Communication: A Computational Guide (Under Review)
- [1] Yeon, J.\*, Peng, Y., **Lu, Y.**, Khawar, S.\*, & Shen, C. From “Just Jokes” to “Biased Truth”: How Politician-featured Memes Shape Credibility Judgments of Political (Mis)information (Under Review)

## SELECTED WORKS IN PROGRESS

---

- [3] **Lu, Y.** How Fans Engage with State Propaganda through Celebrity Mobilization (Manuscript in preparation)
- [2] Khawar, S.\*, **Lu, Y.**, Peng, Y., & Yeon, J.\*, & Shen, C. Visual Matters: Connecting Aesthetic Appeal and Production Quality of Photos, Infographics and Data Visualizations to Credibility of Social Media Posts (Manuscript in preparation, [Preprint](#)).
- [1] Peng, Y., Qian, S.\*, **Lu, Y.**, & Shen, C. From Model Reasoning to Interpretable Features: Predicting Visual Credibility with Multimodal Large Language Models (Manuscript in preparation, [Preprint](#))

## GRANTS

---

### External

- Google Cloud Research Credits Program, \$5,000, *PI* 2025-2026
- OpenAI Researcher Access Program, \$5,000 worth of API credits, *PI* 2024-2025  
(with Cuihua (Cindy) Shen and Yilang Peng)
- National Science Foundation (CNS-2150716), \$500,000, *Research Fellow* 2022-2025  
Project title: *Collaborative Research: SaTC: CORE: Small: Understanding How Visual Features of Misinformation Influence Credibility Perceptions* (PI: Cuihua (Cindy) Shen and Yilang Peng)
- Princeton Data-Driven Social Science (DDSS) Initiative, \$10,000, *co-PI* 2022-2023  
Project title: *Propagating the Repressive Apparatus on Social Media: The Case of TikTok*

- Summer Institutes in Computational Social Science (SICSS) Research Grant, \$2,500, *PI* 2021  
Project title: *Invisible Spammers: Detecting Bots on Chinese Social Media*
- Magic Grant from Brown Institute for Media Innovation, \$100,000, *co-PI* 2019–2020  
Project title: *Screenomics Interactive Dashboard*
- Google Cloud COVID-19 Credit Grant, \$250, *PI* 2020  
Project title: *Echo or Divergence: COVID-19 Discourse on Twitter and Weibo*

#### Internal

- Northwestern Buffett Global Working Group Grant, \$200,000, *Core Team Member* 2025–2028  
Project title: *Global Large Language Models Values Benchmarking Project*
- HAI-Google Cloud Credits Grant Program, \$2,171, *PI* 2023  
Project title: *Fandom, Propaganda and State Mobilization on Chinese Social Media*
- Stanford Institute for Research in the Social Sciences (IRiSS) Research Data Grant, \$1,500, *PI* 2022  
Project title: *Fauci Memes Matter: Public Figure Memes and COVID-19 Misinformation*
- Stanford Program on Democracy and the Internet (PDI) Research Funding, \$10,000, *PI* 2020–2021  
Project title: *Multimodal beyond Text: Investigating Visual Misinformation on Social Media*
- Stanford Global Studies (SGS) Global Perspectives Grant, \$3,500, *PI* 2016  
Project title: *Environmental Policy Implementation in China*
- Stanford Center For East Asian Studies Summer Grant, \$3,900 2016

#### Under Review

- National Science Foundation, \$, *co-PI* 2027–2030  
Project title: *Collaborative: SaTC: Multimodal Trust Transfer Under Attack: How AI-Enabled Impersonation Exploits Human and Machine Judgment* (PI: Yingdan Lu & Cuihua (Cindy) Shen)

#### Proposals Not Funded

- Spencer Foundation Research Grants on Education, \$50,000, *PI*  
Project title: *Advancing Media Literacy Programs to Empower Youth to Understand Authoritarian Foreign Propaganda on Video-Sharing Platforms* (Finalist among 54 / 1000)
- Thinking Machines Lab, Interactivity Research Grants, \$100,000, *co-PI*  
Project title: *Measuring Verbosity and Its Human Cost in Multimodal AI*
- Google Academic Research Award program, \$100,000, 2024, *PI*  
Project title: *Empowering the Elderly: Understanding the Impact of AI-Generated Images on Older Adults*
- Data Empowerment Fund, \$100,000, 2024, *PI*  
Project title: *Synthetic Realities: A Dataset of AI-Generated Photorealistic Visuals for Decoding Categories, Elements, and Human Perceptions*
- Sony Research Award Program, \$200,000, *Co-PI*  
Project title: *KAIROS: Knowledge-guided Accurate Video Retrieval from Long-form Storytelling Events*

## AWARDS & HONORS

- Top Paper Award, Political Communication Division, International Communication Association 2026
- Best Lightning Talk Award, 11<sup>th</sup> International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2) 2025
- Top Paper Award, Computational Methods Division, International Communication Association 2025
- Top Student Paper Award, Political Communication Division, International Communication Association 2023
- Stanford Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence (HAI) Graduate Fellowship 2022–2023
- Stanford Institute for Research in the Social Sciences (IRiSS) Dissertation Fellowship 2022–2023
- Stanford Computational Social Science Fellowship 2020–2021

|                                                                                              |           |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| • Stanford Graduate Fellowship in Science & Engineering                                      | 2017–2021 |
| • Stanford Asia Pacific Scholar Fellowship                                                   | 2016      |
| • Stanford Freeman Spogli Institute for International Studies (FSI) Global Policy Fellowship | 2016      |
| • Stanford Silas Palmer Research Fellowship                                                  | 2015      |
| • Beijing Distinguished Graduate Student Award                                               | 2015      |
| • People.cn Best Paper Award (First Prize)                                                   | 2015      |
| • TECO Green Tech Contest (Bronze Medalist)                                                  | 2014      |
| • Evergrande Comprehensive Scholarship                                                       | 2014      |
| • Hang Seng Bank Mainland Scholarship                                                        | 2013      |
| • Rural Investigation and Studies Award by China Institute for Rural Studies                 | 2013      |

## INVITED TALKS & SEMINARS

---

### External Talks and Seminars

|                                                                                                        |                      |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|
| • University of California, Riverside, Department of Political Science Speaker Series                  | Nov 2026 (scheduled) |
| • Linköping University, IAS International Roundtable on Computational Social Science                   | Oct 2026 (scheduled) |
| • Stanford University, Summer Institute in Computational Social Science                                | Aug 2026             |
| • Stanford University, Center for Advanced Study in the Behavioral Sciences                            | Jul 2026             |
| • University of Florida, Summer Institute in Computational Social Science                              | June 2026            |
| • Hoover Institution, Domestic and International Manifestations of Chinese Authoritarianism Conference | May 2026             |
| • Washington University in St. Louis, 13th Comparative Politics Annual Conference                      | Apr 2026             |
| • University of Zurich, Symposium on Computational Visual Media Research                               | Aug 2025             |
| • NYU Abu Dhabi, Politics and Technology in Non-Democratic Contexts Workshop                           | May 2025             |
| • New York University, Equity and the Societal Implications of Global Technologies Symposium           | Apr 2025             |
| • University of Michigan, Political Communication Working Group                                        | Feb 2025             |
| • University of California San Francisco, PRISM Health Symposium                                       | Dec 2024             |
| • University of Washington, Department of Communication                                                | Nov 2024             |
| • University of Wisconsin-Madison, Local News and the Future of Democracy Conference                   | Oct 2024             |
| • New York University, Frontiers in Empirical Research on East Asia                                    | May 2024             |
| • Ohio State University, School of Communication                                                       | Apr 2024             |
| • University of Iowa, School of Journalism & Mass Communication                                        | Feb 2024             |
| • University of Chicago, Computational Social Science Workshop                                         | Feb 2024             |
| • University of Wisconsin-Madison, Computational Methods Research Group                                | Nov 2023             |
| • University of Wisconsin-Madison, Mass Communication Research Center Symposium                        | Oct 2023             |
| • UCLA, Department of Communication                                                                    | Jan 2023             |
| • Dartmouth College, Program in Quantitative Social Science                                            | Dec 2022             |
| • UCSD, China Research Workshop                                                                        | Dec 2022             |
| • University of Maryland, College of Information Studies                                               | Nov 2022             |
| • University of San Francisco, Department of Economics                                                 | Nov 2022             |
| • National University of Singapore, Department of Communications and New Media                         | Oct 2022             |

### External Guest Lectures

|                                                                                        |           |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| • The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill, <i>Computational Social Science</i> | Sep 2025  |
| • University of Minnesota, <i>Summer Workshop on Computational Social Science</i>      | June 2025 |

- University of Wisconsin-Madison, *Social Media Analytics* Apr 2025, Apr 2024, Mar 2023, Mar 2022, Nov 2020
- Montana State University, *Chinese Politics & Policy* Apr 2025
- National University of Singapore, *Summer Institute in Computational Social Science* June 2024
- North Dakota State University, *Advanced Issues in Communication* Oct 2023
- University of California, Davis, *Persuasive Technologies* Nov 2022
- University of San Francisco, *Natural Language Processing* Nov 2020

#### Internal Talks and Presentations

- Northwestern University, Quantitative and Computational Methods Workshop Oct 2026 (Scheduled)
- Northwestern University, 2026 Lambert ANN SONIC NICO Workshop May 2026
- Northwestern University, Phonatics Group Apr 2026
- Northwestern University, Statistical Computing Workshop Feb 2026
- Northwestern University, Northwestern Institute on Complex Systems Wednesday Seminar Nov 2024
- Northwestern University, Culture and Society Workshop Oct 2024
- Northwestern University, Chinese Political Economy Conference May 2024
- Northwestern University, Human-Computer Interaction + Design Center Apr 2024
- Northwestern University, Data Science Nights Oct 2023
- Stanford University, Stanford Center on China's Economy and Institutions May 2023
- Stanford University, Center for Work, Technology, & Organization Dec 2021
- Stanford University, Data Science Lab Feb 2020, Feb 2021

#### Internal Guest Lectures and Talks

- Department of Communication Studies, *CMN 110 Research Fundamentals* Mar 2026
- Department of Political Science, *Politics of China* Feb 2026
- Department of Computer Science, *Misinformation and Disinformation in the Age of AI* May 2024
- Kellogg School of Management, *Emerging Topics in Computational Social Science* Feb 2024

### SELECTED PEER-REVIEWED CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- 
- [60] **Lu, Y.**, Xin, H., Chu, A., Peng, Y., & Shen, C. (2026, September). *Measuring Sound Events in Political Communication: A Computational Guide*. Presented at 2026 American Political Science Association (APSA) Annual Meeting & Exhibition, Boston, USA.
  - [59] Gaw, F., **Lu, Y.**, & Nisbet, E. (2026, September). *Visual Logic: An Integrated Framework for Understanding Visual Content on Social Media*. Presented at 2026 American Political Science Association (APSA) Annual Meeting & Exhibition, Boston, USA.
  - [58] **Lu, Y.**, Xin, H., Chu, A., Peng, Y., & Shen, C. (2026, July). *Measuring Sound Events in Political Communication: A Computational Guide*. Presented at 12<sup>th</sup> International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2), Burlington, USA.
  - [57] Liu, X., **Lu, Y.**, Peng, Q., Qian S., Peng, Y., & Shen, C. (2026, July). *Seeing the Surreal: Mapping Surrealism in Photorealistic AI-Generated Images Using Large Language Models*. Poster presented at 12<sup>th</sup> International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2), Burlington, USA.
  - [56] Liu, X., Peng, Y., & **Lu, Y.** (2026, July). *Mitigating Confounder Bias in Observational Studies of Visual Media Effects*. Poster presented at 12<sup>th</sup> International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2), Burlington, USA.
  - [55] Gaw, F., **Lu, Y.**, & Nisbet, E. (2026, July). *Visual Logic: An Integrated Framework for Understanding Visual Content on Social Media*. Poster presented at 12<sup>th</sup> International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2), Burlington, USA.

- [54] **Lu, Y.**, Xin, H., Chu, A., Peng, Y., & Shen, C. (2026, July). *Measuring Sound Events in Political Communication: A Computational Guide*. Presented at the 43rd Annual Meeting of the Society for Political Methodology (PolMeth XLIII), East Lansing, USA.
- [53] Liu, X., Peng, Y., & **Lu, Y.** (2026, July). *Mitigating Confounder Bias in Observational Studies of Visual Media Effects*. Poster presented at the 43rd Annual Meeting of the Society for Political Methodology (PolMeth XLIII), East Lansing, USA.
- [52] **Lu, Y.**, Xin, H., Chu, A., Peng, Y., & Shen, C. (2026, June). *Audio as Data: Understanding Sound Events in Political Communication*. Presented at 76<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Cape Town, South Africa.
- [51] **Lu, Y.**, Liu, X., & Zhou, C. (2026, June). *Recommending the State: How Social Media Algorithms Curate State Content in China*. Presented at 76<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Cape Town, South Africa.
- [50] Liu, X., **Lu, Y.**, Peng, Q., Qian, S., Peng, Y., & Shen, C. (2026, June). *Seeing the Surreal: Mapping Surrealism in Photorealistic AI-Generated Images Using Large Language Models*. Presented at 76<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Cape Town, South Africa.
- [49] Khawar, S., **Lu, Y.**, Peng, Y., Yeon, J., & Shen, C. (2026, June). *Visual Matters: Connecting Aesthetic Appeal and Production Quality of Photos, Infographics and Data Visualizations to Credibility of Social Media Posts*. Presented at 76<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Cape Town, South Africa.
- [48] Yeon, J., Peng, Y., **Lu, Y.**, Khawar, S., & Shen, C. (2026, June). *From “Just Jokes” to “Biased Truth”: How Politician-featured Memes Shape Perceptions Of Political (Mis)information*. Presented at 76<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Cape Town, South Africa.
- [Top Paper Award, Political Communication Division]**
- [47] **Lu, Y.**, Liu, X., & Zhou, C. (2025, September). *Recommending the State: How Social Media Algorithms Curate State Content in China*. Presented at 2025 American Political Science Association (APSA) Annual Meeting & Exhibition, Vancouver, Canada.
- [46] **Lu, Y.**, Liu, X., & Zhou, C. (2025, July). *Recommending the State: How Social Media Algorithms Curate State Content in China*. Presented at 11<sup>th</sup> International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2), Norrköping, Sweden.
- [Best Lightning Talk Award]**
- [45] **Lu, Y.** (2025, July). *How Fans Engage with State Propaganda through Celebrity Mobilization*. Poster presented at 11<sup>th</sup> International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2), Norrköping, Sweden.
- [44] DeButts, M., & **Lu, Y.** (2025, July). *Intimacy with limits: How short-form video propaganda embraces platform norms, but not for leaders*. Presented at 11<sup>th</sup> International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2), Norrköping, Sweden.
- [43] Peng, Y., Qian, S., **Lu, Y.**, & Shen, C. (2025, July). *Large Language Model-Informed Feature Discovery Improves Prediction and Interpretation of Credibility Perceptions of Visual Content*. Presented at 11<sup>th</sup> International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2), Norrköping, Sweden.
- [42] **Lu, Y.** (2025, July). *How Fans Engage with State Propaganda through Celebrity Mobilization*. Presented at 28<sup>th</sup> International Political Science Association (IPSA) World Congress of Political Science, Seoul, South Korea.
- [41] **Lu, Y.** (2025, June). *How Fans Engage with State Propaganda through Celebrity Mobilization*. Presented at 75<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Denver, USA.
- [40] DeButts, M., & **Lu, Y.** (2025, June). *Intimacy with limits: How short-form video propaganda embraces platform norms, but not for leaders*. Presented at 75<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Denver, USA.
- [39] Peng, Y., Qian, S., **Lu, Y.**, & Shen, C. (2025, June). *Large Language Model-Informed Feature Discovery Improves Prediction and Interpretation of Credibility Perceptions of Visual Content*. Presented at 75<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Denver, USA.
- [Top Paper Award, Computational Methods Division]**

- [38] Dahlke, R., Tu, F., Wang, Y.C., **Lu, Y.**, Engeda, B.W. & Hancock, J. (2025, June). *Contextualizing Misinformation: A User-Centric Approach to Linguistic and Topical Patterns in News Consumption*. Presented at 75<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Denver, USA.
- [37] **Lu, Y.** (2024, September). *How Fans Engage with State Propaganda through Celebrity Mobilization*. Presented at 2024 American Political Science Association (APSA) Annual Meeting & Exhibition, Philadelphia, USA.
- [36] Hanley, H., **Lu, Y.**, & Pan, J. (2024, July). *Across the Firewall: Foreign Media's Role in Shaping Chinese Social Media Narratives on the Russo-Ukrainian War*. Presented at 10<sup>th</sup> International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2), Philadelphia, USA.
- [35] **Lu, Y.** (2024, June). *Performative Propaganda Engagement: How Celebrity Fandom Engages with State Propaganda in China*. Presented at 74<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Gold Coast, Australia.
- [34] Hanley, H., **Lu, Y.**, & Pan, J. (2024, June). *Narratives of Foreign Media Ecosystems in Chinese Social Media Discussions of the Russo-Ukrainian War*. Presented at 74<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Gold Coast, Australia.
- [33] Peng, Q., **Lu, Y.**, Qian, S., Peng, Y., Liu, X., & Shen, C. (2024, June). *Crafting Synthetic Realities: Examining Visual Realism and Misinformation Potential of Photorealistic AI-Generated Images*. Presented at 74<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Gold Coast, Australia.
- [32] Divon, T., & **Lu, Y.** (2024, June). *Invisible States and Visible Strategies: Navigating Political Influence on TikTok and Douyin in Israel and China*. Presented at 74<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Gold Coast, Australia.
- [31] Jia, C., Kim, S., & **Lu, Y.** (2024, June). *Nudging Emotions via AI: Examining the Effect of Emotion-Interventions on Reducing Susceptibility to Text and Image Misinformation*. Presented at 74<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Gold Coast, Australia.
- [30] Hanley, H., **Lu, Y.**, & Pan, J. (2023, November). *Narratives of Foreign Media Ecosystems in Chinese Social Media Discussions of the Russo-Ukrainian War*. Presented at The New Directions in Analyzing Text as Data (TADA) 2023 meeting, Amherst, USA.
- [29] **Lu, Y.** (2023, September). *Performative Propaganda Engagement: How Celebrity Fandom Engages with State Propaganda in China*. Presented at 2023 American Political Science Association (APSA) Annual Meeting & Exhibition, Los Angeles, USA.
- [28] **Lu, Y.**, & Peng, Y. (2023, September). *The Mobilizing Power of Visual Media Across Stages of Social Movements*. Presented at 2023 American Political Science Association (APSA) Annual Meeting & Exhibition, Los Angeles, USA.
- [27] Hanley, H., **Lu, Y.**, & Pan, J. (2023, September). *Narratives of Foreign Media Ecosystems in Chinese Social Media Discussions of the Russo-Ukrainian War*. Presented at 2023 Politics and Computational Social Science (PaCSS) conference, Los Angeles, USA.
- [26] **Lu, Y.**, & Peng, Y. (2023, July). *The Mobilizing Power of Visual Media Across Stages of Social Movements*. Presented at the 40th Annual Meeting of the Society for Political Methodology (PolMeth XL), Stanford, USA.
- [25] Hanley, H., **Lu, Y.**, & Pan, J. (2023, July). *Influence of foreign and domestic media ecosystems on Chinese social media*. Presented at the 40th Annual Meeting of the Society for Political Methodology (PolMeth XL), Stanford, USA.
- [24] **Lu, Y.**, & Peng, Y. (2023, May). *The Mobilizing Power of Visual Media Across Stages of Social Movements*. Presented at 73<sup>rd</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Toronto, Canada. **[Top Student Paper Award, Political Communication Division]**
- [23] Chen, K., **Lu, Y.**, & Zou, S. (2023, May). *TikToking Vaccine Nationalism: Examining COVID-Vaccine-Themed Videos on Douyin through a Mixed-Method Analysis*. Presented at 73<sup>rd</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Toronto, Canada.
- [22] Qian, S., **Lu, Y.**, Peng, Y., Shen, C., & Xu, H. (2023, May). *Convergence or Divergence? A Systematic Comparison of Visual Posts between Twitter and Instagram*. Presented at 73<sup>rd</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Toronto, Canada.

- [21] **Lu, Y.**, Schaefer, J., Park, K., Joo, J., & Pan, J. (2023, March). *How Information Flows from the World to China*. Presented at International Studies Association (ISA) 64<sup>th</sup> Annual Convention, Montréal, Québec, Canada.
- [20] Chen, K., **Lu, Y.**, & Wang, Y. (2022, November). *Toward an Evidence-Driven Understanding of Digital Trace Research on China*. Presented at National Communication Association (NCA) 108<sup>th</sup> Annual Convention, New Orleans, USA.
- [19] **Lu, Y.**, Pan, J., Xu, X., & Xu, Y. (2022, September). *The Evolution of Propaganda in the Digital Age: Chinese Government Mobilization on Douyin*. Presented at 2022 American Political Science Association (APSA) Annual Meeting & Exhibition, Montréal, Québec, Canada.
- [18] **Lu, Y.**, Schaefer, J., Park, K., Joo, J., & Pan, J. (2022, September). *How Information Flows from the World to China*. Presented at 2022 American Political Science Association (APSA) Annual Meeting & Exhibition, Montréal, Québec, Canada.
- [17] **Lu, Y.**, Pan, J., Xu, X., & Xu, Y. (2022, July). *The Evolution of Propaganda in the Digital Age: Chinese Government Mobilization on Douyin*. Presented at 8<sup>th</sup> International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2), Chicago, USA.
- [16] **Lu, Y.**, & Shen, C. (2022, July). *Unpacking Multimodal Fact-Checking: Features and Engagement of Fact-Checking Videos on Chinese TikTok (Douyin)*. Presented at 8<sup>th</sup> International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2), Chicago, USA.
- [15] Christin, A., & **Lu, Y.** (2022, July). *The Influencer Pay Gap: Platform Labor Meets Racial Capitalism*. Presented at Society for the Advancement of Socio-Economics (SASE) 34<sup>th</sup> Annual Meeting, Amsterdam, The Netherlands.
- [14] **Lu, Y.**, Pan, J., Xu, X., & Xu, Y. (2022, May). *The Evolution of Propaganda in the Digital Age: Chinese Government Mobilization on Douyin*. Presented at 72<sup>nd</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Paris, France.
- [13] **Lu, Y.**, Schaefer, J., Park, K., Joo, J., & Pan, J. (2022, May). *How Information Flows from the World to China*. Presented at 72<sup>nd</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Paris, France.
- [12] **Lu, Y.**, & Shen, C. (2022, May). *Unpacking Multimodal Fact-Checking: Features and Engagement of Fact-Checking Videos on Chinese TikTok (Douyin)*. Presented at 72<sup>nd</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Paris, France.
- [11] **Lu, Y.**, Liu, S., & Hancock, J. (2022, May). *Computational Approaches to Understanding Credibility in Video-Based Misinformation: An Analysis of COVID-19 Content on TikTok*. Presented at 72<sup>nd</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Paris, France.
- [10] Chen, K., Zou, S., & **Lu, Y.** (2022, May). *Thanks to My Country's Love!: Examining Nationalist Narratives in COVID Vaccine-Related Videos on Douyin Through Large-Scale Visual and Textual Analysis*. Presented at 72<sup>nd</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Paris, France.
- [9] **Lu, Y.**, Pan, J., Xu, X., & Xu, Y. (2022, April). *The Evolution of Propaganda in the Digital Age*. Presented at 80<sup>th</sup> Midwest Political Science Association Annual Conference (MPSA), Chicago, USA.
- [8] **Lu, Y.**, & Shen, C. (2021, September). *Unpacking Multimodal Fact-Checking: Features and Engagement of Fact-Checking Videos on Chinese TikTok*. Presented at The 3<sup>rd</sup> Multidisciplinary International Symposium on Disinformation in Open Online Media (MISDOOM), virtual.
- [7] **Lu, Y.**, Pan, J., & Xu, Y. (2021, September). *Public Sentiment on Chinese Social Media During the Emergence of COVID-19*. Presented at 2021 American Political Science Association (APSA) Annual Meeting & Exhibition, virtual.
- [6] **Lu, Y.**, & Pan, J. (2021, August). *The Pervasive Presence of Chinese Government Content on Douyin Trending Videos*. Presented at 104<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference of Association for Education in Journalism and Mass Communication (AEJMC), virtual.
- [5] **Lu, Y.**, & Pan, J. (2021, July). *The Pervasive Presence of Chinese Government Content on Douyin Trending Videos*. Presented at 7<sup>th</sup> International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2), virtual.
- [4] **Lu, Y.**, & Pan, J. (2020, September). *Capturing Clicks: How the Chinese Government Uses Clickbait to Compete for Visibility*. Presented at 2020 American Political Science Association (APSA) Meeting & Exhibition, virtual.

- [3] **Lu, Y., & Pan, J.** (2020, August). *Capturing Clicks: How the Chinese Government Uses Clickbait to Compete for Visibility*. Presented at 6<sup>th</sup> International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2), virtual.
- [2] **Lu, Y., & Pan, J.** (2020, May). *Capturing Clicks: How the Chinese Government Uses Clickbait to Compete for Visibility*. Presented at 70<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), virtual.
- [1] **Lu, Y., Muise D., Pan, J., & Reeves, B.** (2018, May). *Micro-Level Natural Interaction with Information Systems: An International Screenshot Comparison*. Presented at 68<sup>th</sup> Annual Conference of the International Communication Association (ICA), Prague, Czech Republic.

## TEACHING

---

|                                                                                                         |                  |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| <b>COMM_ST 101-1: Communication in Context: Introduction</b><br>Undergraduate lecture (required course) | 2026             |
| <b>COMM_ST 379 / POLI_SCI 390: Digital Propaganda and Repression</b><br>Undergraduate lecture           | 2024, 2025, 2026 |
| <b>MTS 501: Introduction to Graduate Research</b><br>Ph.D. seminar (required course)                    | 2025, 2026       |
| <b>MTS 525: Computational Communication Research</b><br>Ph.D. seminar                                   | 2024, 2025       |

## Workshops

- Northwestern University, *MSC Professional Development Practicum: AI-Powered Social Media Analytics* Mar 2025
- Organizational Communication Mini Conference 2024, *OCMC Workshop: Unpacking Organizational Communication through Computational Multimodal Analysis* Sep 2024
- Northwestern University, *Summer Institute in Computational Social Science* August 2024

## ADVISING

---

### Ph.D. Advisor

- Xinyi Liu, Media, Department of Communication Studies, Northwestern University (current)
- Haohang (Otto) Xin, Department of Communication Studies, Northwestern University (current)

### Dissertation Committee Member

- Fatima Gaw, Department of Communication Studies, Northwestern University (current)
- Artur Baranov, Department of Political Science, Northwestern University (current)
- Xi Cheng, Department of Sociology, Northwestern University (current)
- Chen-Wei (Felix) Yu, Human Development and Social Policy, Northwestern University (current)
- Qiyao Peng, Department of Communication, University of California, Santa Barbara (current)
- Yuting He, Moody College of Communication, The University of Texas at Austin (current)
- Chloe Mortenson, Department of Communication Studies, Northwestern University (Defended)
- Mowafak Allaham, Department of Communication Studies, Northwestern University (Research Engineer, Emergence)
- Rod Abhari, Department of Communication Studies, Northwestern University (Postdoc, UW-Madison)

## ACADEMIC SERVICE

---

### Association-related Service:

International Communication Association (ICA):

- Panel Chair, “Addressing Methodological Challenges in LLM-enhanced Computational Communication” (2026)
- Panel Chair, “Innovations in Multimodal Data Analysis” (2026)
- Invited Panel Speaker, [ICA@75 ANNIVERSARY SPECIAL SESSION: Generative AI: Transforming/Disrupting Communication Scholarship](#) (2025)
- Panel Chair, “Political Propaganda” (2025)
- Panel Chair, “AI’s Role in Political Campaigns and Public Discourse” (2025)
- Organizer, “[The Future of Computational Message Science: Theoretical Advances, Computational Frontiers, and Grand Societal Challenges](#)” Pre-conference (2024)
- Panel Chair, “Image-as-Data Methods” (2024)
- Panel Discussant, “Leveraging Generative AI in Communication Research: Opportunities, Challenges, and Best Practices” (2024)
- Award Committee, Best Paper Award for the ICA Computational Methods Division (2024)
- Mentor, Communication and Technology Division Research Escalator (2024)
- Panel Chair, “Video-as-data in Computational Communication: Toward a Mixed-Method Pathway” (2023)
- Panel Chair, “Video-as-data in Computational Communication” (2022)
- Panel Chair, “Propaganda in the Computational Age: Disinformation and Beyond” (2020)

American Political Science Association (APSA):

- Program Chair, APSA Political Communication Section (2028)
- Co-organizer, [APSA Pre-Conference in Political Communication](#) (2026)
- Panel Chair, “Preprocessing, Annotation, and Interpretation in Computational Social Science” (2023)

ACM Web Science Conference:

- Workshop and Tutorial Co-Chair, [ACM Web Science Conference 2027](#)

International Political Science Association (IPSA) conference:

- Discussant, “Political Communication Across the Globe” (2025)

Politics and Computational Social Science (PaCSS) conference: Panel Chair, “Chinese Politics” (2023)

Text-as-Data (TADA) conference: Doctoral Consortium Mentor (2023)

Authoritarian Political Systems Group: Discussant (2025)

### University and Departmental Service:

Department of Communication Studies:

- Master of Science in Communication Advisory Committee, Department of Communication Studies (2025-2026)
- Department Advisory Committee, Department of Communication Studies (2024-2025)
- Department Finance Committee, Department of Communication Studies (2024-2025)
- Co-Organizer, MTS Colloquium (2024-2025)
- Graduate Admissions Committee, Technology & Social Behavior PhD Program (2023-2024)

Northwestern University:

- Organizer, [2026 Lambert ANN SONIC NICO Workshop: Reimagining Human-Centered Computing Research in the Age of AI](#)
- Co-Organizer, [Center for Human-Computer Interaction + Design Symposium “Validating Generative AI-Based Social Sciences”](#)
- Co-Organizer, [2024 Summer Institute in Computational Social Science \(SICSS\)-Chicago](#)
- Faculty Advisor, [2024 Organizational Communication Mini Conference \(OCMC\)](#)

Stanford University:

- Department Liaison, Institute for Research in the Social Sciences (2019–2023)
- International Student Chair, Department of Communication (2020–2022)
- Alumni Mentor, Center for East Asian Studies (2022, 2021, 2019)
- Group Coordinator, Professor Jennifer Pan’s Research Group (2018–2020)
- Student Assistant, State of the Field in Chinese Politics Conference (2018)
- Conference Assistant, Digital Humanities Asia 2018 Summit (2017)

**Founder, *COMputation Island***

- An online platform established in 2021 for computational communication research (12,000+ followers)
- Organized this platform to share cutting-edge research in computational social science, facilitate academic discussions, and promote resource exchanges to students and scholars in Asia and other regions.
- Wrote and edited articles to introduce computational social science studies, methods, and resources to students and scholars in communication, political science, and other disciplines.
- Led and managed the platform maintenance, editor recruitment, editorial work, and platform outreach.

**Reviewer:**

Peer-reviewed Journals:

- *Nature*
- *Journal of Communication*
- *American Political Science Review*
- *American Journal of Political Science*
- *Science Advances*
- *The Journal of Politics*
- *Political Communication*
- *Communication Research*
- *Human Communication Research*
- *Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication*
- *Communication Methods and Measures*
- *New Media & Society*
- *Political Analysis*
- *Comparative Political Studies*
- *Information, Communication & Society*
- *Digital Journalism*
- *International Journal of Press/Politics*
- *Social Media and Society*
- *Computational Communication Research*
- *Sociological Methods and Research*
- *International Journal of Communication*
- *PLoS ONE*
- *Humanities and Social Sciences Communications*
- *Political Psychology*
- *Communication Theory*
- *China Quarterly*
- *Chinese Journal of Communication*

- *Political Research Quarterly*
- *International Journal of Public Opinion Research*
- *Visual Communication Quarterly*
- *Qualitative Sociology*
- *Asian Studies Review*
- *Communication & Society*

Conference Proceedings:

- *ACM CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems*

Grant Proposals: National Science Foundation

## OTHER RESEARCH EXPERIENCES

---

|                                                                                                    |                                  |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------|
| <b>Social Media Lab, Stanford University</b><br>Student Affiliate                                  | Stanford, CA<br>2022–2023        |
| <b>Human Screenome Project, Stanford University</b><br>Student Affiliate                           | Stanford, CA<br>2017–2023        |
| <b>Stanford Data Science Collaboratory, Stanford University</b><br>Student Member                  | Stanford, CA<br>2019–2021        |
| <b>Japan International Cooperation Agency Research Institute (JICA-RI)</b><br>Global Policy Intern | Tokyo, Japan<br>Jun–Sep, 2016    |
| <b>USC Annenberg Center for the Digital Future</b><br>Research Intern                              | Los Angeles, CA<br>Jun–Aug, 2014 |

## SKILLS

---

- **Statistical Programming/Markup Languages:** R, Python, Stata, SPSS,  $\text{\LaTeX}$ , SQL
- **Languages:** Mandarin (Native), English (Proficient), Korean (Intermediate), Japanese (Elementary)
- **Applications:** Tableau, Adobe Creative Suite, Premiere Pro, Final Cut Pro
- **Music:** Guzheng (Level 8 Certificate), Band Performing